

What Do I Do When...? Situation Guide Collection

English

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They keep repeating the same story

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

The story may carry identity, pleasure, reassurance, or an unmet need.

WHAT TO DO

Receive it as meaningful; listen for a new detail; ask about feeling; connect it to a photo, person, place, or song.

TRY SAYING

“What did you enjoy most about that?”

AVOID

Do not say “You already told me.”

WATCH FOR

Notice warmth, energy, anxiety, or fatigue.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Offer a related photo or gently move to another familiar subject.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They cannot remember a name

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

Word retrieval can be difficult even when the person recognizes the relationship or feeling.

WHAT TO DO

Give the name freely; add a warm cue; continue without making it a test.

TRY SAYING

“That’s Meera, your neighbor. She has such a warm smile.”

AVOID

Do not withhold the answer or demand guessing.

WATCH FOR

Watch relief, recognition, frustration, or withdrawal.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Shift to what the person in the photo is doing or how the image feels.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They cannot find the right word

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

The idea may be present even when a word is hard to retrieve.

WHAT TO DO

Wait; keep eye contact; offer one possible word only if helpful; attend to gesture and tone.

TRY SAYING

“Take your time. Do you mean the garden?”

AVOID

Do not finish every sentence or pretend to understand.

WATCH FOR

Watch whether help feels welcome.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Invite pointing, drawing, or choosing between two images.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They say something that seems incorrect

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

The factual detail may matter less than the feeling or meaning.

WHAT TO DO

Respond to emotion; avoid unnecessary correction; ask about the broader experience.

TRY SAYING

“That sounds like it was an important day.”

AVOID

Do not argue about dates, names, or sequence.

WATCH FOR

Watch for rising tension or ease.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Move to a sensory or preference question.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They do not answer

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

They may need more processing time, may not hear, may be tired, or may not wish to answer.

WHAT TO DO

Wait quietly; check sound; simplify; offer a choice; accept silence.

TRY SAYING

“No hurry. We can just look at this together.”

AVOID

Do not repeat rapidly or speak about them as if absent.

WATCH FOR

Notice gaze, gesture, breathing, and comfort.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Make an observation instead of asking another question.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

Conversation stops

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

A pause is normal; the topic may be finished or too demanding.

WHAT TO DO

Allow silence; summarize a pleasant thread; share something small; offer one familiar prompt.

TRY SAYING

"I liked hearing about your school. Mine had a very noisy bell."

AVOID

Do not fire off several questions.

WATCH FOR

Watch for renewed eye contact or fatigue.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Use a photo, song, object, or a simple choice.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They seem confused

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

The question, setting, technology, or topic may be unclear.

WHAT TO DO

Slow down; orient gently; use one idea; reduce background noise; reassure.

TRY SAYING

“We’re having our Thursday video call. I’m Riya, and I’m glad to see you.”

AVOID

Do not challenge or shame.

WATCH FOR

Watch for distress or a sudden change from usual.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Return to a familiar person, routine, or object; caregivers escalate acute change.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They become frustrated

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

Effort, misunderstanding, noise, pain, or feeling corrected may be contributing.

WHAT TO DO

Pause; validate; reduce demands; apologize if needed; offer a break or change.

TRY SAYING

“This feels frustrating. We can stop or try something easier.”

AVOID

Do not insist on finishing.

WATCH FOR

Watch voice, face, movement, and signs of pain.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Change topic or end gently; caregivers escalate concerning change.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They lose interest

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

The topic may not fit, energy may be low, or the activity may feel like work.

WHAT TO DO

Stop the activity; name a familiar interest; invite a choice; follow nonverbal cues.

TRY SAYING

“Shall we leave this and listen to a song?”

AVOID

Do not push for completion.

WATCH FOR

Notice looking away, shorter answers, or renewed energy.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Try one personally meaningful item.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They do not want the activity

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

Refusal is communication and a valid choice.

WHAT TO DO

Accept it; thank them for telling you; offer conversation, another option, or rest.

TRY SAYING

“Of course. We don’t have to do it.”

AVOID

Do not persuade repeatedly or treat refusal as misbehavior.

WATCH FOR

Watch whether pressure is causing distress.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Ask what would feel comfortable, or simply be present.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They seem tired

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

Conversation can require effort; time of day, health, or the environment may matter.

WHAT TO DO

Reduce length; slow down; offer rest; end early without disappointment.

TRY SAYING

“You seem ready for a rest. We can finish for today.”

AVOID

Do not interpret fatigue as failure.

WATCH FOR

Watch eyes closing, slower response, discomfort, or sudden change.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

End warmly; caregivers report unusual fatigue.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They become emotional

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

A memory, loss, joy, or unmet need may be close to the surface.

WHAT TO DO

Stay calm; acknowledge feeling; allow tears; ask what support would help; respect privacy.

TRY SAYING

“This brings up a lot. I’m here with you.”

AVOID

Do not dismiss, interrogate, or force positivity.

WATCH FOR

Watch comfort, escalating distress, and safety.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Offer a comforting topic, music, person, or pause; follow safeguarding when needed.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

You cannot understand what they are saying

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

Speech may be unclear, but gesture, key words, expression, and context can carry meaning.

WHAT TO DO

Listen for key words; ask one clarifying choice; use gesture or writing; be honest kindly.

TRY SAYING

"I want to understand. Did you say tea or TV?"

AVOID

Do not pretend or ask them to repeat endlessly.

WATCH FOR

Watch frustration and whether another method helps.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Ask about the feeling or show two options.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

They ask the same question repeatedly

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

The answer may not stick, or the question may express worry or a need for reassurance.

WHAT TO DO

Answer calmly; use the same simple wording; write or show the answer; respond to emotion.

TRY SAYING

“Your daughter is coming after lunch. You’re safe here while you wait.”

AVOID

Do not point out the repetition.

WATCH FOR

Watch for anxiety beneath the question.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Move to a reassuring routine or familiar activity.

What Do I Do When...?

What do I do when...?

You do not know what to say next

WHAT MAY BE HAPPENING

You do not need to perform. A shared observation can restart connection.

WHAT TO DO

Pause; return to something they enjoyed; share a little about yourself; offer two topics.

TRY SAYING

“Would you rather talk about food or music?”

AVOID

Do not fill every second or turn to memory quizzes.

WATCH FOR

Watch which word, image, or subject creates a spark.

IF IT STILL DOES NOT WORK

Use a Passion Pack or end warmly if the moment is complete.

Evidence note: Informed by the seven systematic reviews and evidence syntheses listed at sageandseed.org/full-references.html. Evidence for communication skills and meaningful interaction is more consistent than evidence for broader clinical outcomes.

This practical resource supports communication and engagement. It is not medical advice, therapy, clinical training, or certification. Follow local safeguarding and supervisory procedures.